SQL Quest — Student Guide

SQL Quest · Student Guide · 2026-11-05

SQL Quest teaches you databases by playing. You read a short **lesson**, try a **challenge**, get **instant feedback**, earn **XP** and **badges**, and unlock the next level. Each world ends with a timed **boss battle**.

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1. Getting started

Create your account

1. Open the SQL Quest web address your teacher gave you.
2. Click **Create a student account**.
3. Fill in your **display name** (what classmates see), a **username** (3–24 letters or numbers) and a **password** (at least 6 characters).
4. Type the **class join code** from your teacher, for example `DBQ-201`. You can skip this and join later.
5. Click **Create account**. You're in!

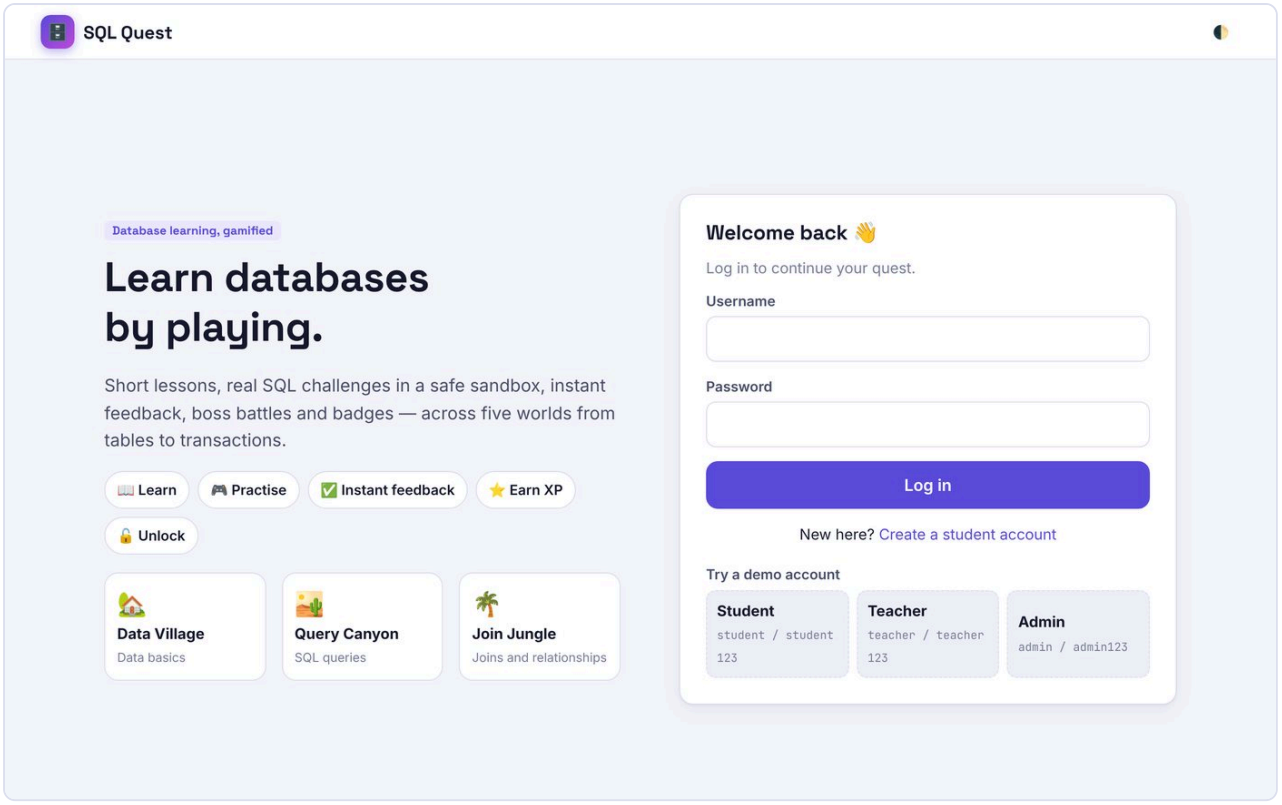
> If sign-up is turned off, your teacher or administrator will give you a username and password instead.

Log in

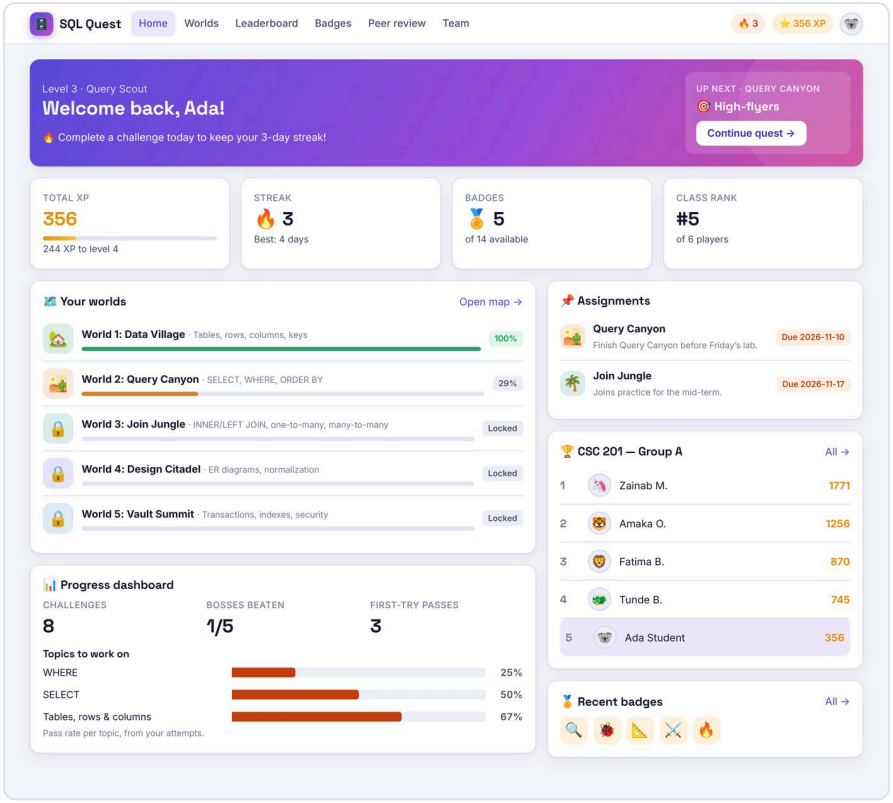
Enter your username and password and click **Log in**. You stay logged in on that device until you log out (account menu → **Log out**).

Join a class later

On your **Home** page, use the **Join your class** box, or go to the account menu → **Profile & settings** → **Class**. Joining a class lets you see your teacher's **assignments**, the **class leaderboard**, **peer review** and **team missions**.



2. Your home page (dashboard)

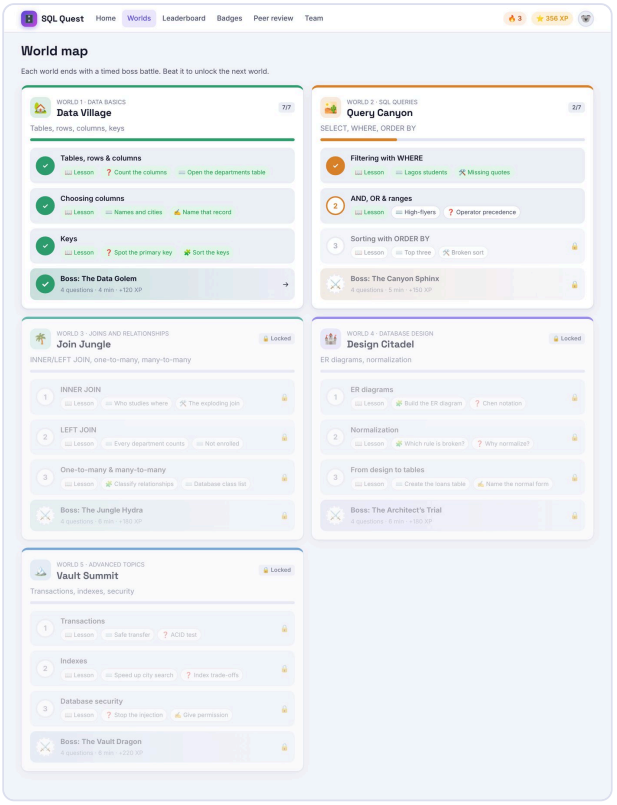


Area	What it shows
Welcome banner	Your level and title, and whether today's practice has kept your streak alive.
Up next	The next lesson, challenge or boss. Click **Continue quest →** to go straight there.
Total XP	Your points, plus how many more you need for the next level.
Streak	How many days in a row you have practised, and your best streak.
Badges	How many badges you have earned.
Class rank	Your position on your class leaderboard.
Your worlds	Progress bars for the five worlds. 🔒 means locked.
Progress dashboard	Challenges done, bosses beaten, first-try passes, and **Topics to work on**: the topics where you fail most often.
Assignments	Worlds your teacher has set, with due dates.
Leaderboard / Recent badges	Your class top 5 and your latest badges.

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3. The world map

Click **Worlds** in the top menu.



There are five worlds, in order:

World	Topics
🏡 1. Data Village	Tables, rows, columns, keys
🏜️ 2. Query Canyon	SELECT, WHERE, ORDER BY
🌴 3. Join Jungle	INNER JOIN, LEFT JOIN, one-to-many, many-to-many
🏰 4. Design Citadel	ER diagrams, normalization, CREATE TABLE
🏔️ 5. Vault Summit	Transactions, indexes, security

Each world has **3 levels**. Each level has a 📖 **lesson** and **2 challenges**. After the three levels comes the ⚔️ **boss**.

How things unlock

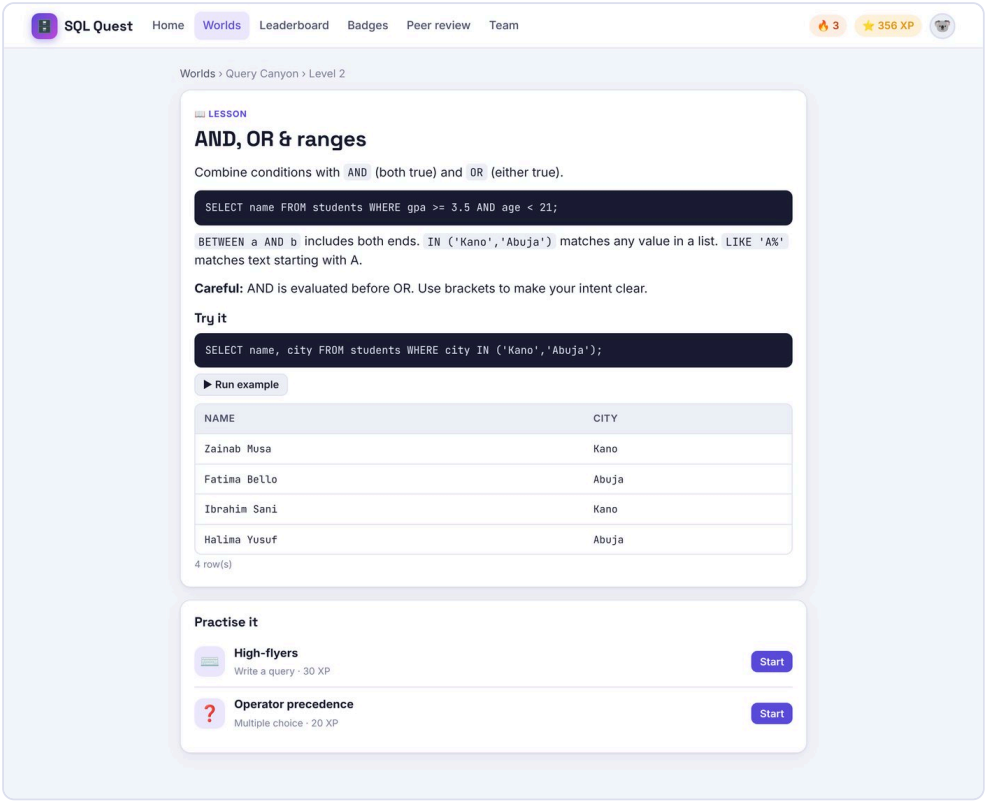
- Finish both challenges in a level to unlock the next level.
- Finish every level in a world to wake the boss.
- Beat the boss to unlock the next world.
- Your teacher can also unlock a world early by assigning it.

Challenges marked ⭐ are **bonus challenges** added by your teacher. They earn XP but are optional: they never lock you out of anything.

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4. Lessons

A lesson explains one idea with short examples. Click ▶ **Run example** to see the example query's result. At the bottom, **Practise it** lists the level's challenges.



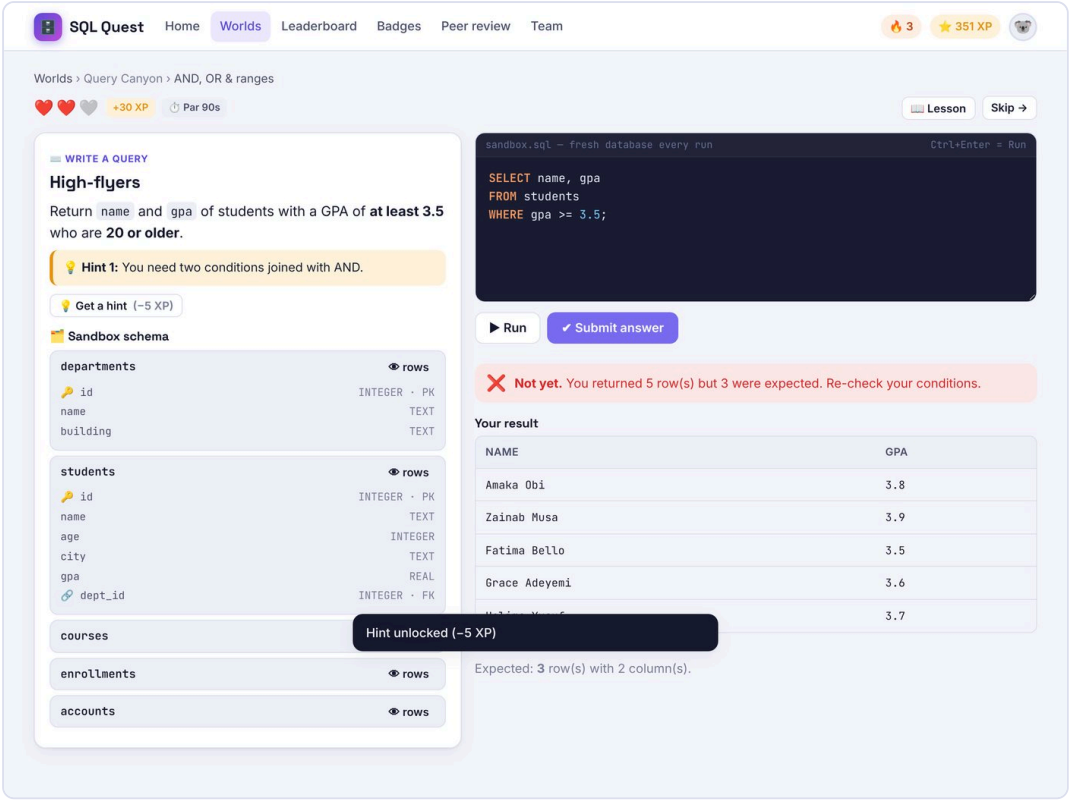
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5. Challenges

There are five kinds of challenge:

Icon	Type	What you do
⌨️	**Write a query**	Write SQL that returns the requested result.
🛠️	**Fix the query**	A broken query is given. Repair it.
❓	**Multiple choice**	Pick one answer, then click **Check answer**.
✍️	**Short answer**	Type a word or short phrase. Capital letters don't matter.
🧩	**Drag & drop**	Drag each item into the right box: keys, relationships, ER diagrams, normal forms.

The SQL editor



- ▶ **Run** (or **Ctrl + Enter**) shows your result. It does **not** count as an attempt and never costs a life. Run as often as you like.
- ✔ **Submit answer** sends your answer to be marked. A wrong answer costs a ❤️ life.
- ↺ **Reset** (in "Fix the query" challenges) brings the broken query back.
- 🗂️ **Sandbox schema** (left) lists every table and column. 🔑 marks a primary key and 🔗 a foreign key. Click 👁 **rows** to see the data.
- The practice database is **reset every time you run**, so you can't break anything.

Feedback

After you submit, a message tells you what's wrong, for example:

Message	What to check
You returned 12 row(s) but 3 were expected	Your WHERE conditions.
this question needs a WHERE filter	You forgot to filter rows.
Missing JOIN condition	Add `ON a.column = b.column` to your JOIN.
should this be a LEFT JOIN?	INNER JOIN drops rows with no match.
Right rows, wrong order	Your `ORDER BY` column, or ASC/DESC.
no such column: Lagos	Text needs single quotes: `'Lagos'`.
different number of columns	Return exactly the columns asked for, no more and no fewer.

You also see **Expected: N row(s) with M column(s)** so you know what to aim for. Row order doesn't matter unless the question asks you to sort.

Lives and retries

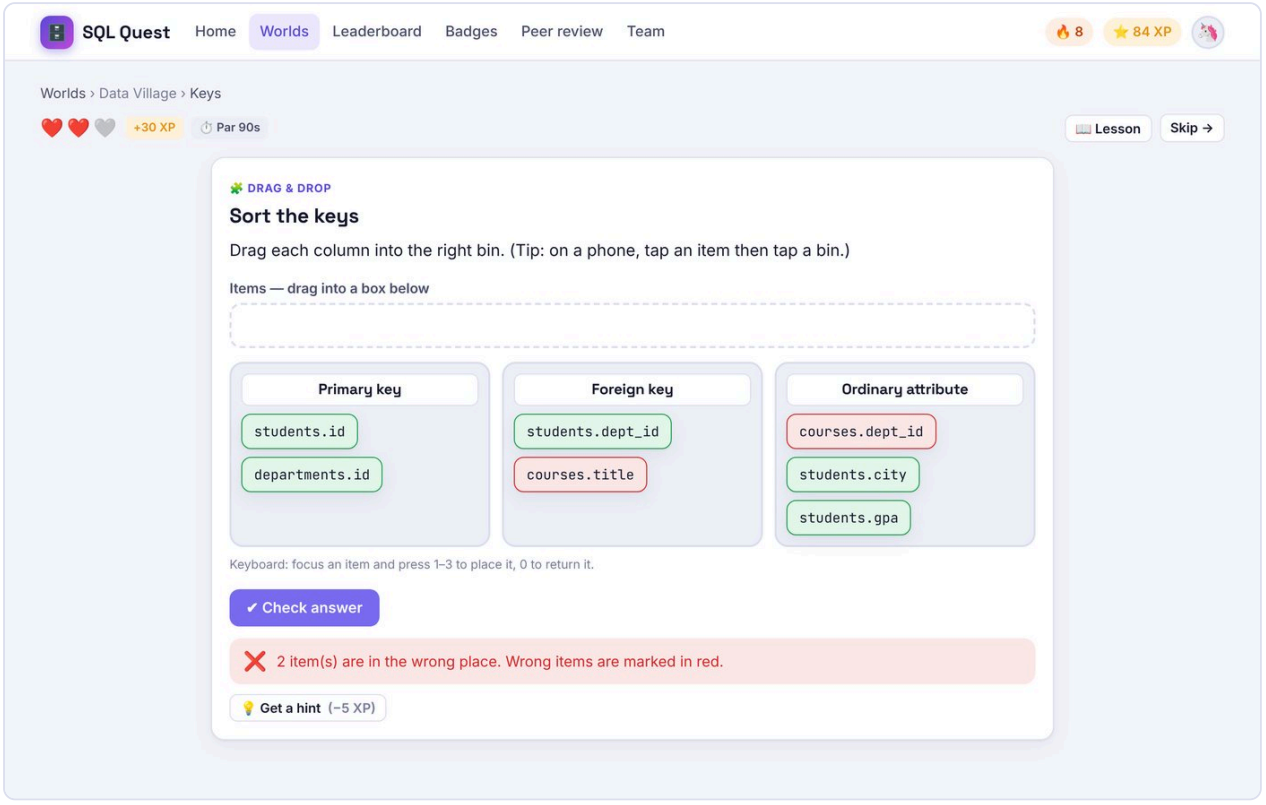
You have **3 lives** ❤️❤️❤️ per challenge. If you lose them all, you can 📖 **Review the lesson** or ↻ **Retry**. A retry after losing all lives earns **half the normal XP**.

Hints

Click 💡 **Get a hint** to see a tip. Each hint **costs 5 XP**. Hints you have bought stay visible if you come back.

Drag & drop on a phone

Tap an item, then **tap** the box it belongs in. Items marked red after checking are in the wrong box.

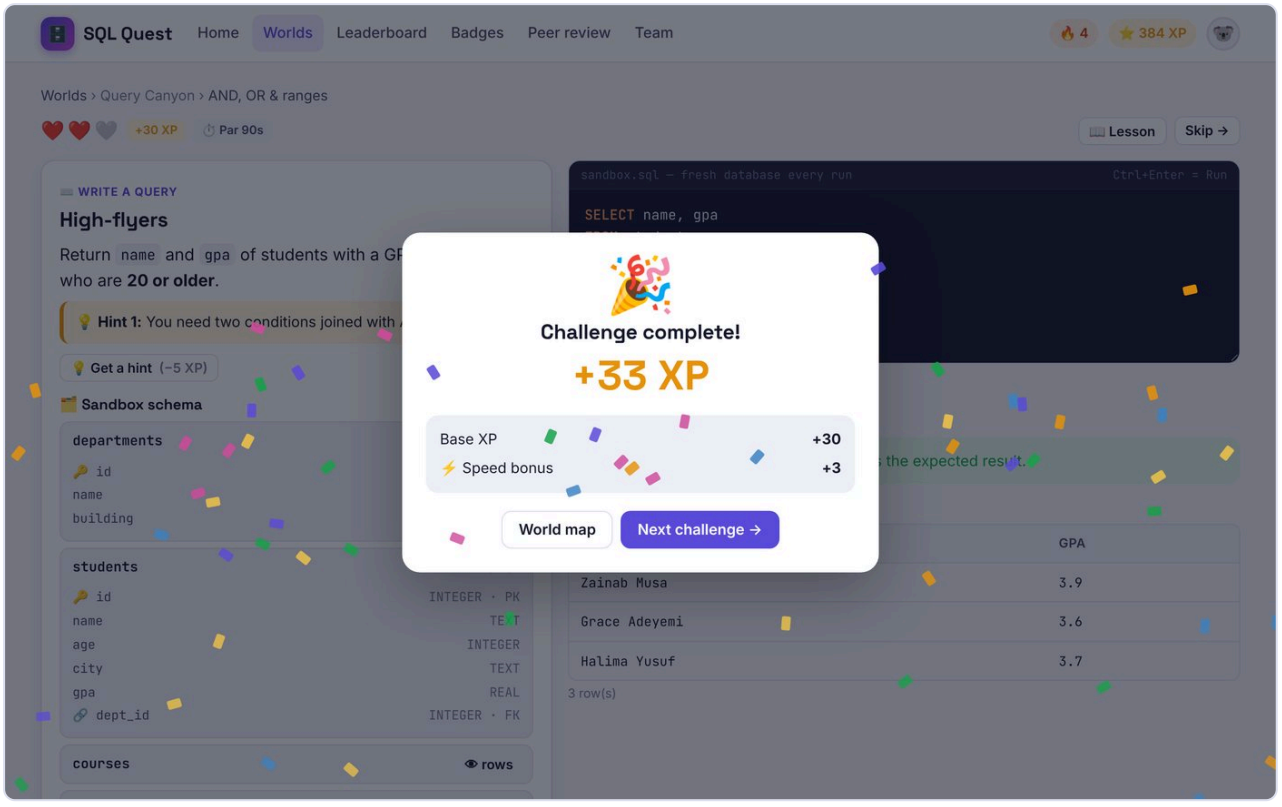


6. XP, levels and bonuses

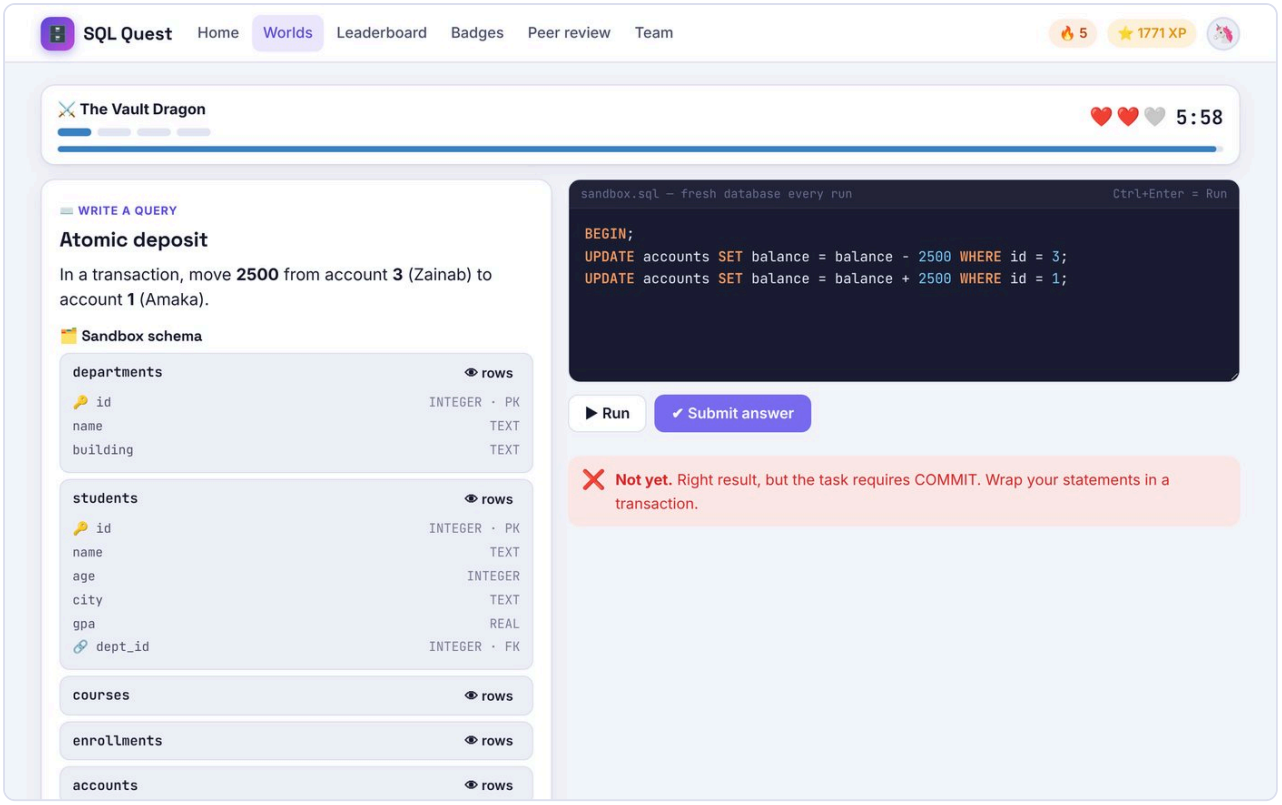
When you pass a challenge for the first time you earn:

Base XP	Shown on the challenge (for example +30 XP).
⚡ **Speed bonus**	+10% if you finish within the **par time** (shown as ⏱️ Par).
🎯 **Accuracy bonus**	+20% if you had **no wrong attempts**.
⭮ **Retry penalty**	−50% if you had lost all your lives before passing.

Replaying a finished challenge is good practice but earns no extra XP. Level titles go from *Novice* → *Apprentice* → *Query Scout* → *Data Ranger* → *Join Knight* → *Schema Sage* → *Index Wizard* → *Vault Keeper* → *DB Legend*.



7. Boss battles ⚔️



- A boss has **4 questions** that mix everything from its world.
- You have a **time limit** (4–6 minutes) and **3 lives** for the whole battle.
- **No hints!**
- A wrong answer costs a life. You can try the same question again.
- Win to earn the boss XP **plus a time bonus and a bonus for lives left**, and to unlock the next world.
- If time or lives run out, review the lessons and **Try again**. The boss resets fully.

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8. Streaks and badges

Streak 🔥: every day, pass at least one *new* challenge, beat a boss, or give a peer review. Replays don't count. Missing a day resets the streak to 0.

> The numbers in this guide (3 lives, 5 XP per hint, +10% / +20% bonuses) are the defaults. Your administrator can change them.

Badges 🏅 are awarded automatically. Open **Badges** to see them all, including the locked ones. Examples:

	Badge	How to earn it
🔍	First Query	Pass your first SQL challenge
🔗	First JOIN	Pass a challenge using a JOIN
🐞	Bug Squasher	Fix your first broken query
📐	Architect	Complete a drag-and-drop design mission
⚔️	Boss Slayer	Defeat your first boss
👑	Grand Master	Defeat all five bosses
🔥 / 🌋	On Fire / Ten-Day Streak	Practise 3 / 10 days in a row
💎	Perfectionist	Pass 10 challenges on the first try
🧐	Peer Reviewer	Review a classmate's query
🤝	Team Player	Complete a team mission

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9. Leaderboard

Leaderboard shows your **class** ranking and the **global** ranking by XP, with a podium for the top three. Your row is highlighted.

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10. Peer review 🧐

Open **Peer review**.

- **Share a query:** pick a SQL challenge you have passed, add an optional question, and click **Share**. Classmates see it **anonymously** ("Classmate #3").
- **Review classmates:** read a classmate's query, give 1–5 ⭐ and written feedback. You earn **+15 XP** for each review (once per query).
- **My shared queries:** read the feedback you received.

Only queries you choose to share are visible. Nobody can see your other answers.

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11. Team missions 🤝

If your teacher puts you in a team, open **Team**.

- Every member can write a draft and click 💾 **Save team draft** so the others can see it.
- Only the 👑 **team leader** can **Submit**.
- When the leader passes, **every member** earns the XP and the **Team Player** badge.

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12. Profile and settings

Account menu (your avatar, top right) → **Profile & settings**:

- change your **display name** and **avatar**
- **join or switch class**
- **change your password**
- see your **4-week activity** calendar

🌓 **Toggle dark mode** is in the same menu.

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13. Questions and problems

I forgot my password. Ask your teacher or administrator to reset it.

A world or level shows 🔒. Finish the earlier level or boss first, or ask your teacher to assign the world.

My query works when I click Run, but Submit says it's wrong. Run only shows your result. Compare it with the question: check the columns, the filter, the sort order and the number of rows.

"Blocked command". Commands like `DROP TABLE` are not allowed in the sandbox. Use the statements the question asks for.

"Time limit exceeded". Your query ran too long (often an endless loop or a JOIN with no ON). Simplify it.

My progress disappeared. If your school runs the *browser-only* version, progress is saved only in the browser and device you used. Use the same device and browser, and don't clear browsing data. On the *server* version, progress is saved online and follows you to any device.